

# Fate's Edge Quickstart

Your first session in 15 minutes

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## Welcome to Fate's Edge

You are exiles, rogues, and survivors in a world where every choice carries weight and every roll of the dice can change the story. This Quickstart contains everything you need to play your first session:

- Core rules (2 pages)
- 4 pre-generated characters
- A complete starter adventure: *The Lantern at Dusk*
- Game Master tips

No other books required.

## 1 Core Resolution

When your character attempts something risky or uncertain:

1. **Declare** what you want to achieve and how (*Attribute + Skill*).
2. **GM sets Difficulty Value (DV)**: 2 (easy), 3 (standard), 4 (hard), 5+ (extreme).
3. **GM sets Position**: Dominant (safe), Controlled (normal), Desperate (dangerous).
4. **Roll** a number of d10s = Attribute + Skill.
5. **Count successes** (each 6–10 = 1 success). Each 1 gives the GM a **Story Beat (SB)**.
6. **Compare successes to DV** using the table below.

## Outcome Matrix

| Result          | Condition                          | Effect                               |
|-----------------|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Clean Success   | successes $\geq$ DV, SB=0          | You do it, no complication.          |
| Success with SB | successes $\geq$ DV, SB $\geq$ 1   | You do it, GM spends SB for a twist. |
| Partial         | $0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$ | You make progress, gain 1 Boon.      |
| Miss            | successes = 0                      | You fail, gain 2 Boons.              |

## Boons

Boons represent luck and momentum. Hold up to 5. At the end of a scene, reduce to 2 (lost excess). Spend 1 Boon to:

- Re-roll a single die after seeing the pool.
- Improve your Position by one step before rolling.
- Activate an Asset (see character sheets).
- Convert 2 Boons  $\rightarrow$  1 XP (once per session, max 2 XP).

## Story Beats (SB) – GM Only

Spend SB to introduce complications:

- 1 SB – minor: noise, dropped item, tick a timer.
- 2 SB – moderate: alarm raised, lose cover.
- 3+ SB – serious: reinforcements, scene shift.

## 2 Combat in Brief

Same as above, with these additions:

- **Turn order**: Narrative initiative – GM spotlights based on fiction. Ambushers act first.
- **Move**: Shift one range band (Close  $\leftrightarrow$  Near  $\leftrightarrow$  Far) as a free movement.

- **Action:** Attack, cast a spell, use a talent, etc.
- **Opportunity attack:** Leaving Close range without using *Disengage* provokes one free melee attack.
- **Fatigue:** Each point of Fatigue worsens Position one step (Dominant→Controlled→Desperate). If already Desperate, each Fatigue gives -1 die. Full rest removes all.
- **Harm:** Harm 1 (-1 die), Harm 2 (-2 dice), Harm 3 (incapacitated).

### 3 Attributes & Skills

| Attribute | What it does                 | Example Skills               |
|-----------|------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Body      | strength, agility, endurance | Melee, Athletics, Stealth    |
| Wits      | perception, quick thinking   | Insight, Lore, Investigation |
| Spirit    | willpower, intuition         | Resolve, Arcana, Survival    |
| Presence  | charisma, leadership         | Sway, Command, Deception     |

**Skill ratings:** 0 untrained, 1 novice, 2 competent, 3 expert, 4 master, 5 legendary.

### 4 Pre-Generated Characters

Choose one. All are balanced for the starter adventure.

#### 1. Kael – Soldier

*Once a legionary, now a sellsword.*

**Body 3, Wits 2, Spirit 2, Presence 1**

**Skills:** Melee 3, Athletics 2, Endurance 1, Command 1

**Talent – Battle Instincts:** Once per scene, reroll a failed defense roll.

**Asset – Trusted Blade:** Your sword never breaks on a Miss.

**Bonds:** (choose one with another PC) "I saved your life outside Millhaven."

#### 2. Lyra – Scholar

*Expelled from the Academy for forbidden research.*

**Wits 3, Spirit 3, Body 1, Presence 1**

**Skills:** Lore 2, Arcana 2, Investigation 2, Insight 1

**Talent – Lorekeeper:** Once per session, recall obscure history without rolling.

**Asset – Scholar's Satchel:** Contains books, reagents, a small telescope.

**Bonds:** "We both lost our place in Silkstrand."

#### 3. Sera – Shadow

*Former guild thief, now a wanderer.*

**Wits 3, Body 2, Spirit 2, Presence 1**

**Skills:** Stealth 3, Subterfuge 2, Streetwise 1, Melee 1

**Talent – Silver Tongue:** +1 die to persuade or deceive through speech.

**Asset – Shadow's Cloak:** +1 die to stealth rolls in dim light.

**Bonds:** "You kept my secret when the guards came."

#### 4. Mira – Healer

*Accused of witchcraft for curing the incurable.*

**Spirit 3, Wits 2, Body 2, Presence 1**

**Skills:** Medicine 3, Survival 2, Insight 2, Nature 1

**Talent – Iron Stomach:** Immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food.

**Asset – Healer's Kit:** Bandages, herbs, basic medical supplies.

**Bonds:** "You trusted me when no one else would."

Each PC starts with **3 Boons** and **0 Fatigue/Harm**.

### 5 Starter Adventure – The Lantern at Dusk

#### Setup

The party is hired by Elder Sarai of the remote village of **Duskwood**. A terrible blight is spreading from the old barrow in the hills – the same barrow where a cursed lantern was buried centuries ago. The lantern must be brought to a stone circle in the valley to break the curse. But the barrow is not empty.

#### What the Party Knows

- The lantern is in the central chamber of the barrow.

- The barrow is guarded by restless spirits (the **Duskwights**).
- A rival treasure hunter, **Quick Lena**, has also entered the barrow.
- The curse will kill the village's crops in three days.

## Clocks

- **Barrow Collapse [6]** – ticks when the party fails a roll inside (GM advances 1 segment per Miss). At 6, the entrance seals – escape becomes a Desperate group action.
- **Lena's Agenda [4]** – ticks at the end of each scene inside the barrow. When it fills, Lena has already taken the lantern; the party must chase her.

## Scene 1 – The Entry

The barrow entrance is a narrow stone passage. A faint green glow pulses from deeper inside. **Obstacle:** A cave-in blocks the way (Body+Athletics to climb, DV 3, Controlled). *Partial:* You get through but disturb rubble – tick Barrow Collapse +1. *Miss:* You are pinned by a rock – mark Harm 1 and tick Collapse +1.

## Scene 2 – The Spirit Corridor

The passage widens into a hall where three Duskwights drift. They do not attack unless provoked, but they will not let anyone pass without an offering. **Offer a memory or a secret** (Presence+Sway, DV 3, Controlled). *Clean Success:* They bow and let you pass. *Partial:* They take your offering but also steal a random piece of equipment (GM chooses). *Miss:* They attack as a single mob (Cap 2, Harm 1 each, 2 Fatigue each on hit). Combat follows normal rules.

## Scene 3 – The Lantern Chamber

The lantern sits on a stone altar. Quick Lena is there, trying to pry it loose. **Confront Lena:** She is not a fighter. Offer a deal or intimidate her (Presence+Sway, DV 3, Controlled). *Success:* She leaves peacefully, but warns that "others will come for it." *Partial:* She agrees to split any reward but demands a favor later (start a Debt Clock [4]). *Miss:* She triggers a trap – a stone door starts closing (tick Collapse +2).

## Scene 4 – Escape

After you take the lantern, the barrow begins to collapse in earnest. **Group skill challenge:** The party needs 3 successes before 2 failures to escape. Each PC describes how they help (e.g., Athletics to brace a door, Lore to read ancient escape runes). DV 3, Position Desperate. Each failure ticks Collapse +1. If Collapse reaches 6 before you escape, the entrance seals – you must find another way (start a second Clock [4] to dig out, each success removes 1 segment; on failure, mark Fatigue). *Success:* You burst into the moonlight, lantern in hand. *Failure:* You escape, but someone is left behind – captured or lost. The remaining party must rescue them later.

## Resolution

Return the lantern to the stone circle. Breaking the curse requires a simple ritual (Spirit+Lore, DV 2). *Success:* The blight lifts. Elder Sarai rewards each PC with a **String** – "The village owes you." *Partial:* The curse lifts, but the lantern cannot be destroyed – it will attract another danger soon. *Miss:* The curse is only pushed back one year. A dark spirit escapes and will become a recurring enemy.

## Advancement

Each PC earns **6–10 XP** at the end. XP can be spent:

- Raise an Attribute: new rating × 3 XP (downtime = new rating days)
- Raise a Skill: new level × 2 XP (downtime = new level days)
- Learn a Minor Talent (2–4 XP) – examples: *Keen Senses, Second Wind, Combat Reflexes*
- Acquire a Minor Asset (4 XP) – safehouse, contact, or special tool.

**Rush rule:** Skip downtime by accepting a *Haste timer* [4]. If it fills before you finish, the new ability has a flaw (GM's choice).

## 6 GM Tips – Running Your First Game

- **Start strong:** Use the cold open – "The barrow's green light flickers. You smell rot. What do you do?"
- **Set DV to 3** by default. Only raise to 4 or 5 if the task is truly legendary.

- **Spend SB early and often.** A single SB can turn a quiet scene into a tense one.
- **Fail forward:** On a Miss, never say "nothing happens." Always introduce a new complication or advance a timer.
- **Use the pre-gens** – they are designed to showcase different play styles.
- **Keep the spotlight moving.** Ask quiet players directly: "Sera, what are you doing while this happens?"
- **End on a cliffhanger.** When the lantern is lifted, describe the ceiling cracking – then say "to be continued."

## Optional – Magic in One Page

If a player wants a magical character, use these simplified rules (based on the *Free Caster* path).

### Spellcasting

Choose a magical **Element** (Fire, Water, Earth, Air, Fate, Life, Luck, Death). Describe your spell using **TAGS**. Each tag increases DV by 1. Dangerous tags (Teleport, Transform, Dominate) increase DV by +2 instead. **DV = 1 + number of tags** (max 6). Roll **Spirit + Arcana**.

Example: "I throw a [Burning] [Area] blast" = DV 3.

### Backlash

If you roll a Miss or the GM spends SB, magic backfires:

- 1–2 SB: minor flare, Fatigue 1, eerie sound.
- 3+ SB: Harm 1, the spell affects an ally, or a Patron omen appears.

### Sample Spells (DV 2–4)

- *Light* [Illuminate] – DV 2. Create a small, sustained light.
- *HEAL* [HEAL] – DV 2. Heal 1 Fatigue from yourself or a touched ally.
- *Shield of Air* [Ward] [Defend] – DV 3. Gain Position +1 on next defense.
- *Flame Cloak* [Burning] [Area] – DV 3. Enemies suffer –1 die to approach.

For full magic systems (Runekeepers, Invokers, Cantors), see the complete *Fate's Edge Player's Guide*.

## License & Credits

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## Ready for More?

This Quickstart gives you a complete first session. For the full experience:

- **Player's Guide:** Attributes, Skills, Talents, magic systems, character advancement, and the world.
- **GM Guide:** Clocks, fronts, advanced Story Beat management, faction rules, and high-tier play.
- **Adventures:** *Blood and Silk* (village defense), *Beyond Millhaven* (mediation), *The Brass Gate* (heist).

All available under CC-BY from the author. Now gather your dice and step into the Edge.